

iReplaceable?

When Steve Jobs resigned late in August – despite everyone expecting it some time soon anyway, due to his ill health – Apple stock quickly fell a few points. The web was more reactive, and news stories popped up everywhere and speculations abound about how it's the end of an era, and the decline of Apple has begun...

Jobs is credited with bringing Apple out of near bankruptcy, and in just over a decade, increasing the stock value of the company over 100-fold. There aren't too many other people who can claim to have taken a struggling company, and led it to become the biggest tech company on the planet, so it's obvious that there are some XXXL-sized shoes to fill. Many believe that Tim Cook will be able to successfully handle things after Jobs, but there are also those who feel that Jobs is irreplaceable.

This is not the first time we've seen such reactions: pretty similar things were said when Bill Gates left Microsoft to pursue philanthropy, full-time. Many people have cited Microsoft's lack of ground-breaking innovation thus far in the age of tablets and smart phones as definitive proof that Gates' hands-on, day-to-day involvement is being sorely missed at Redmond.

All of this is just an opportunity for us media people to make up some creative headlines, get some extra eyeballs and try to invent new ways to tell the same story over and over again; but will it really affect Apple that much? I don't see it happening for quite some time, if at all. Just as Microsoft went through a lean phase in innovations whilst Apple and Google took over gadgets and the web, the future will probably see the reverse happening at some point. Much like the hardware wars between Intel, AMD and NVIDIA, the software wars will continue to see different brands emerge victorious from various battles, but none will win the war for your attention.

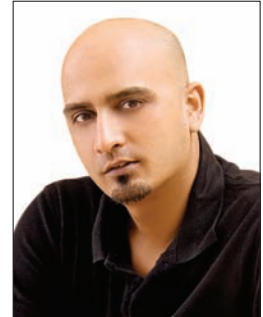
Of course leaders are important, and visionaries even more so, but given a decade, all of them are usually quite successful at transferring their visions down the chain of command. When it's an unsuccessful vision, it changes pretty quickly,

and when it's super-successful, Apple-like, you can bet your life savings on the fact that the company will not try and fix what isn't broken, and the vision will continue unhindered – the board of directors exist for this very reason, doesn't it?

Leaders are extremely important in life; take for example, the anti-corruption rallies we're seeing around us, and even taking part in – without the catalyst that Anna Hazare is, none of us would be parading the streets fighting against the corruption that we've experienced almost all our lives. Real life needs wake-up calls. Products, or even brands, for that matter, are a different ball game.

No normal person flocks to Facebook because they love Mark Zuckerberg, or buys Apple products because they idolize Steve Jobs... it's all about the end product. Despite Jobs being credited for almost everything Apple has done over the past decade, you can bet there were hundreds, if not thousands of innovative ideas from scores of Apple employees that went into making the iPods, iPhones and iPads that the company has made billions from. No one man is ever solely responsible for a company of that size, or for products that popular.

"Just avoid holding it in that way" was Jobs' response to a complaint about the now infamous death grip of the iPhone. This of course sparked all sorts of reactions: some found it a cool reply, other thought it was unacceptable, but everyone went ahead and bought it anyway. Such was the draw to the device, that even an arrogant CEO, an obvious flaw in the product and web-wide bashing didn't put a dent in sales, then why would a change in the helm matter to the iPeople? No one is iReplaceable these days, and for that matter, no product is either... 



Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
editor@thinkdigit.com

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